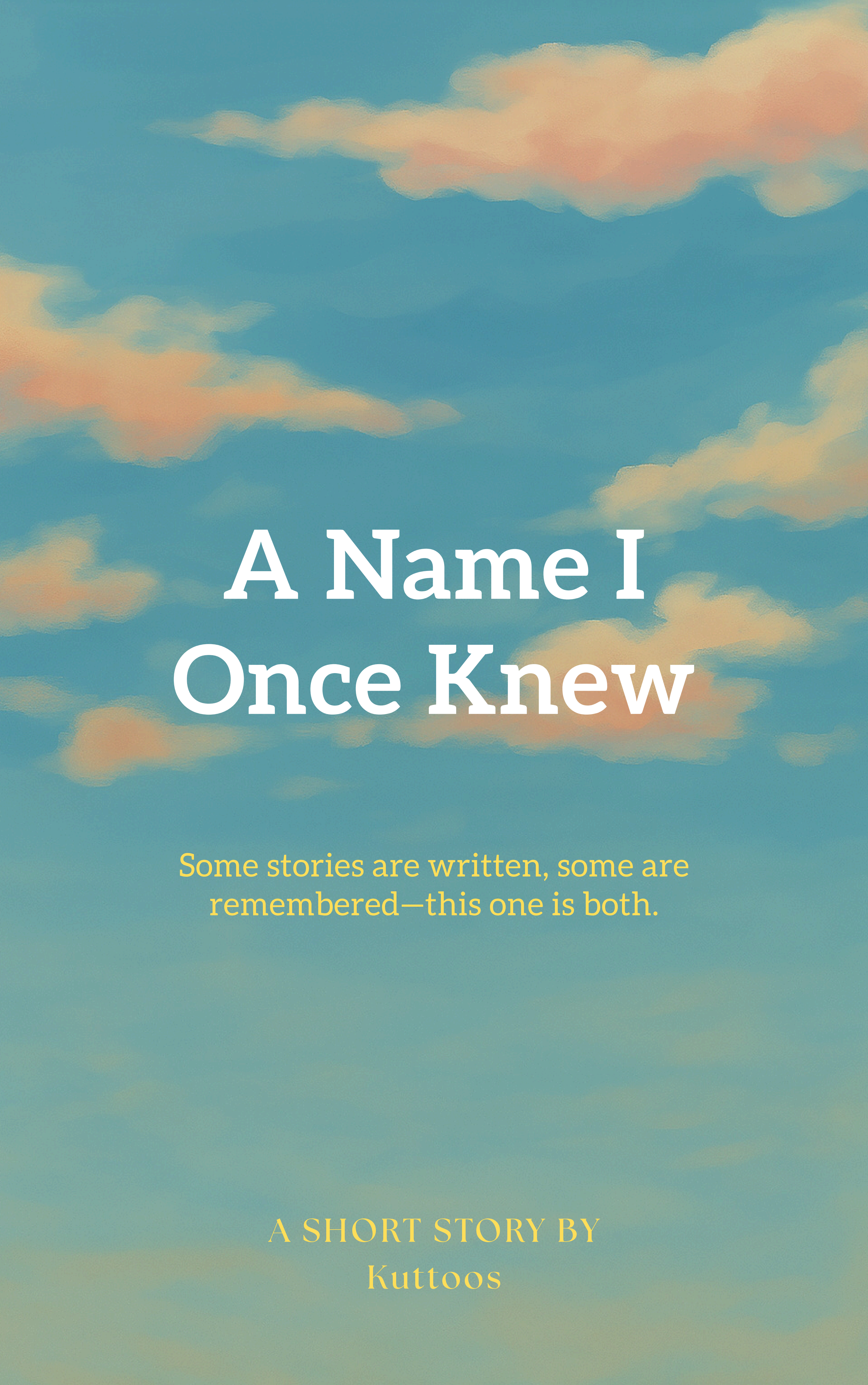




A Name I Once Knew

Some stories are written, some are
remembered—this one is both.

A SHORT STORY BY
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This is a true story from when I was in 10th standard.

It was November, and Cosmos 2.0 was approaching. Cosmos was an inter-school event hosted by my school. The previous year, when I was in 9th standard, I had volunteered to build paper poly models for one of the exhibits. Apparently I had done a decent enough job, because when Cosmos returned, the student's cabinet, who were the organizers, decided to rope me in again.

This time, however, I wasn't just building models. I was given responsibility.

Now before your imagination gets carried away, "responsibility" in this case simply meant being attached to one of the participating teams and making sure they didn't break any rules. There were around five or six teams participating, each representing a different school.

The event itself was fairly straightforward.

Every team would be given a collection of Christmas-themed items to sell. Bells, decorations, candy canes, and other things that suddenly become desirable the moment December appears on the calendar. The team that managed to generate the most revenue would win.

Simple.

At least on paper.

The real challenge wasn't the event.

The real challenge was talking to people.

I was the sort of student who liked sitting on the third bench and disappearing into the background. I studied in an all-boys school, which meant my interactions with girls were rare enough to qualify as special occasions. Looking back, I wasn't scared of girls exactly. I just had no idea what to do with them once they started talking.

Naturally, fate assigned me to a team consisting of two girls.

I still remember the moment I saw them.

One of them immediately caught my attention.

The strange thing is that memory has been unfair about it. I no longer remember her face completely. If you asked me to draw her today, I couldn't. What remains are fragments.

Highlights.

Like someone tore a photograph into pieces and only a few survived.

I remember she had dusky skin. I remember her hair was smooth and straight. I remember rich brown eyes. And I remember her smile.

The lips are difficult to explain.

Not because they were extraordinary in any objective sense, but because fifteen-year-old me had never looked at someone's face long enough to notice things like that. It was the first time I had become aware of details that had probably always existed.

Her friend looked completely different. She wore glasses and had the sort of appearance that instantly convinced me she was the intelligent one. She ended up doing most of the talking throughout the day, which was fortunate because every time the other girl spoke, I temporarily forgot how conversations worked.

I don't know what impression they had of me. They probably thought I was strict.

Or arrogant.

Or one of those event volunteers who took themselves too seriously.

The truth was much less impressive.

I was hanging on for dear life.

Every question directed at me required an embarrassing amount of internal processing.

They would ask something. My brain would panic. Then eventually a reply would emerge. Looking back, it's a miracle communication happened at all.

As the day progressed, we wandered around campus trying to sell the items we had been given.

There was one important rule. Teams weren't allowed to sell products to members of their own team.

Unfortunately, my school had forgotten one small detail. Nobody had proper identification. As a result, determining who belonged to which team became less of an administrative process and more of a philosophical exercise.

The girls adapted quickly.

Soon they were selling Christmas bells worth ten rupees for absurd amounts of money. At one point I watched someone buy a bell for five hundred rupees.

Five hundred. For a bell.

The buyers insisted they weren't teammates.

The sellers insisted they weren't teammates.

I suspected everybody was lying.

Unfortunately, suspicion is difficult to convert into evidence.

At one point they even tried selling a bell to me. Not buying one was the closest I came to enforcing the rules all day.

Hours later, somehow, they had sold everything.

Every decoration. Every bell. Every last item.

As the event wound down, they handed me two bells as a souvenir.

The three of us eventually ended up sitting on the elevated stage overlooking the quadrangle.

For the first time all day, nobody was trying to buy anything. Nobody was negotiating. Nobody was arguing.

The event was finally over.

I remember looking at the sky when she suddenly asked, "*Do you think we'll win?*"

The question genuinely surprised me.

I had watched them struggle to manage over three thousand rupees in cash. At one point they seemed more worried about losing the money than winning the competition.

If they didn't win, I was prepared to file a formal complaint with reality itself.

"You probably will," I said.

Her eyes widened. *"You sure?"*

"Yeah."

The excitement in her voice was immediate.

Even now, years later, I remember that excitement more clearly than I remember her face. What I don't remember is what I said after that.

Mostly because I didn't say much.

There was a part of me that wanted to ask for her number.

Or her email. Or literally anything that would allow this story to continue existing after sunset. But every possible version of the conversation sounded ridiculous in my head.

So I did what I was best at back then.

Nothing.

The moment passed. Like most moments do.

In the end, they won first place with a collection of roughly three thousand six hundred rupees.

I don't remember who won the overall event.

I don't remember the closing announcements.

I don't even remember how the day officially ended.

What I do remember is watching them celebrate and realizing that I would probably never see her again.

At the time, that thought felt strangely heavy

.
Not heartbreaking. Not tragic. Just heavy.

The strangest part of the story happened afterwards.

Within two days, I forgot her face.

Not gradually. Not over months.

Two days. Gone.

Her name disappeared too.

All I remember is that it started with a V.

All I remember is that it started with a V.

Not Vaishali. Not Vaishnavi.

Something else. Something elegant.

The kind of name that felt like it deserved its own background music. If I could remember it today, I imagine a Kathak performance would begin somewhere in the distance every time someone spoke it aloud.

But memory isn't interested in fairness.

It took her face.

It took her name.

And left me with a handful of details, two Christmas bells, and a story.

Maybe that's why I still think about her sometimes. Not because I knew her. But because I never did.

Somewhere in a school event from years ago, there was a girl whose name started with V.

For a single afternoon, she became the most important person in my world.

And then she disappeared.